8.1 VITAL STATISTICS

Introduction

Demography is a term, generally, concerned with human population and it is also concerned with the social implications of periodical variations taking place in the population with reference to geographical location(s).

Vital Statistics is a branch of Demography, which is the science applied to the analysis and interpretation of numerical facts regarding vital events occurring in human population such as births, deaths, marriages, divorces, migration *etc*.

The following are some of the important definitions of Vital Statistics:

"The whole study of mankind by heredity or environment in so far as the results of their study can be arithmetically stated"

–Arthur Newsholme

"Vital Statistics are conventional numerical records of marriages, births, sickness and deaths by which the health and growth of a community may be studied".

–Benjamin

Vital Statistics is the science of numbers applied to the life history of communities or regions.

8.1.1 Importance of Vital Statistics

Vital Statistics are quantitative measurements on live births, deaths, foetal deaths, infant deaths, fertility and so on.

- Vital Statistics are essential for conducting demographic studies on human community during specific time period.
- Vital Statistics play an important role in the development of a country especially in heath care.
- They are of great use in planning and evaluation of socio-economic and public health development of a country.
- They help to identify factors relating to fluctuations in mortality and fertility rates.
- Maternal and infant mortality are important indications of nation's health, thereby influencing the government to develop policies, funding of programs to maintain quality of health care. Timely documentation of births and deaths is essential to maintain high quality indices.
- They are also of great use for comparison of health indicators at national and international levels.
- They are useful in medical and demographical, actuarial studies and research.
- They are of great use to the government to assess the impact of various family welfare programmes implemented in a country.

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